

DISK WHEEL

The earliest wheels to be used for transportation were solid disks made from wooden planks. They were attached to simple carts, wagons, and chariots that were pulled by horses or oxen. Travel on these vehicles would have been rough and bumpy.



Model of wheel shaped from three wooden planks, c.2000 BCE



Handle used for pushing or pulling cart

Chinese wheelbarrow

WHEELBARROW

The wheelbarrow may have been invented either in ancient Greece between the 6th–4th centuries BCE or in China during the 2nd century CE. While the Greek wheelbarrow had a wheel toward the front, as many barrows do today, the Chinese placed the wheel in the middle.

PRAYER WHEELS

Prayer wheels are an important part of Buddhism, one of the world's major religions. These wheels are hollow metal cylinders containing a scroll printed with a mantra (a holy verse or phrase). Buddhists believe that spinning the wheel, or letting it turn in the wind, is the same as saying a prayer out loud.



WHEEL AND AXLE

In most vehicles today, the wheels driven by the engine are attached to cylindrical shafts, or axles. When the vehicle moves, the shafts and wheels rotate together. The axles of the other wheels are attached to the vehicle and move with it. On the earliest vehicles, all the axles were attached to the wheels.

